
POLISH EARLY MUSIC 1

ANONYMOUS

13th–14th century

Bogurodzica



the two oldest stanzas with their melody

CRITICAL EDITION

from Kraków, Biblioteka Jagiellońska, MS 1619

edited by Mikołaj Derduń

First edition · 2026

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POLISH EARLY MUSIC 1. Anonymous, *Bogurodzica*. First edition, 2026. Edited by Mikołaj Derduń.

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Source files, corrections and later editions: <https://github.com/mderdun/pol-ren/editions/bogurodzica>.

Set in Junicon by Peter S. Baker, in a pressed variant made for the series; music engraved with LilyPond and Gregorio.

INTRODUCTION

BOGURODZICA is the oldest surviving Polish religious song. Its first two stanzas, addressed to the Virgin and to Christ, form the original song; later copies add up to twenty more. The only medieval copy with music for both stanzas is a flyleaf of BJ MS 1619, written shortly after 1400. This edition gives that melody in square notation, with the text of the same copy, an apparatus of musical and textual variants, and notes on the manuscript.

Form. Each stanza has three parts: two parallel lines, then a contrasting third with the refrain (Łoś). The melody varies four short phrases (Surzyński's *a–d*), all traceable to the first line, which turns almost symmetrically on *c'–d'–c'* (Flotzinger; Perz calls the procedure centonate). The cadence of *Maryja* returns at *zwolena*, the second *Maryja* and *Bożyce*. *Dziewica* returns at *zyszczy nam*, *uśysz głosy* and *a dać raczy*. *Twego dzieła Krzciciela* returns at *napęłn myśli* *człowiecze*, and the end of *a na świecie zbożny pobyt* at *po żywocie rajski przebyt*.

Mode. The final is D, with inner cadences on a and F. Chybiński weighed mode 6 because of the F cadences, but settled on mode 1. B appears once, at the melodic peak on *spuści*.

Date and origin. Attribution to St Adalbert (d. 997) begins with 15th- and 16th-century copies, Łaski among them, and no modern scholar accepts it. Łoś placed the text in the late 13th century on linguistic and metrical grounds; Chybiński and Feicht put the melody at the turn of the 13th and 14th centuries. Woronczak (1952) matched the opening phrase to the Holy Saturday litany *Kyrie* in the Graz gradual MS 807 and read the song as a *Kyrie trope*. Flotzinger (2005) showed that the match covers only the first phrase, placed the Graz manuscript at Passau c. 1170, and rejected the trope reading. He dates the song to the late 14th century, in south-eastern Poland with Czech mediation. Feicht (1962) assembled many parallels, among them Jehan de Braine's *Par desous l'ombre d'un bois*, and judged the melody the coherent work of one trained musician. Pikulik (2005) argues that the octave leap after the first *Maryja* rules out a date before the 12th or 13th century and calls the melody a 13th-century cento. Kalina (1880) heard two melodies by different authors; Feicht's analysis superseded this.

SOURCES

Musical witnesses

- (K) Kraków, Biblioteka Jagiellońska, MS 1619, back flyleaf; on Polona. *Base text*. Added to a copy of Latin sermons made by Maciej of Grochów, vicar of Kcynia; before 1408. Stanzas 1–2 with music, in seven systems. Gothic chant notation of German–Messine type, C and F clefs, no custodes. A decorated initial opens each musical section: *B(ogu)*, *U (twego)*, *Z(yszczy)*, *T(wego)*, *U(słysz)*, *S(łysz)*, *A (dać)*.
- (K70) Kraków, Biblioteka Jagiellońska, manuscript of 1570; no shelfmark known. Leans towards *bb* before cadences on *a*.
- (W) Warsaw, library of the Literati Chapel at St John's, MS 998 D, its location in 1907; where it is now is not known. Mensural notation, the only witness with written rhythm.
- (CZ) Częstochowa, Jasna Góra, late 15th century. Lost; known from a drawing reproduced by Woronczak; no shelfmark recorded. Music for the first two lines of stanza 1 only.
- (GN) The Gniezno cathedral melody (manuscript; no shelfmark known), printed in *Przyjaciel Ludu* 4, no. 46 (Leszno, 1838), p. 364. It sets the whole text, with smaller note values and sharps.
- (Z) Warsaw, Biblioteka Ordynacji Zamojskiej, MS 1152 (1672). Mensural; the (K70) version, less accurately written.

Readings of (K70) and (W) are given after Chybiński (1907, pp. 30–41), who sets them out in modern notation. (CZ), (GN) and (Z) are described but not collated.

Text witnesses

- (K408) Kraków, Biblioteka Jagiellońska, MS 408, f. 87^v. Added in the early 15th century to a codex dated 1408. Stanzas 1–14, no music.
- (WA) Warsaw, Biblioteka Narodowa, from Holy Cross, c. 1456. 19 stanzas. Kuzminskyi (2017) gives the shelfmark as ‘ręk. 480, k. 223’; not verified.
- (CZ) As above.
- (K3) Kraków, first half of the 16th century. 23 stanzas. Library and shelfmark not known; Pilat (1879) and Łoś (1922) give none.
- (Ł) Jan Łaski, *Commune incliti Poloniae Regni privilegium* (Kraków: J. Haller, 1506), first in the *Registrum*, attributed to St Adalbert. No music.
- (M) Mateusz z Kościana, 1543.
- (H) Herburt, 1570.
- (S) Skarga, *Żywoty świętych*, 1579.

No copy of the prints (Ł), (M), (H) and (S) has been identified, so no shelfmark is given for them. Pilat (1879) and Kalina (1880) number the Kraków copies the other way round, calling BJ 408 ‘Kraków I’. The sigla here follow the shelfmarks.

EDITORIAL METHOD

This edition follows the rules of the series, set out in the guide *Editorial principles* and cited here by number. What follows is particular to this piece: its choices and its departures.

Melody and text. The melody and text are those of (K). The transcription was made from the facsimile and agrees in every pitch with Chybiński’s (1907).

Pitch. Pitch is fixed by the clefs of (K): final D, range C–d’, mode 1. The single b, on *spuś-ci*, is natural.

Rhythm. (K) has no rhythmic signs, so the score has none.

Text. The text is normalised after Woronczak (1962), keeping the *u* that (K) writes and sets to music at the start of line 1.2.

Bar lines. Bar lines mark the verse structure.



TEXT AND TRANSLATION

CRITICAL TEXT

- 1 Bogurodzica dziewica, Bogiem sławiena Maryja,
u twego syna Gospodzina matko zwolena, Maryja!
Zyszczy nam, spuści nam. Kirielejson.
- 2 Twego dzieła Krzciciela, Bożyce,
ustłysz głosy, napeln myśli człowiecze.
Słysz modlitwę, jąż nosimy,
a dać raczy, jegoz prosimy:
a na świecie zbożny pobyt,
po żywocie rajski przebyt. Kirielejson.

TRANSLATION

*Mother of God, Virgin glorified by God, Mary!
Chosen Mother, Mary, from thy Son the Lord
win for us, send down to us. Lord, have mercy.
For thy Baptist's sake, Son of God,
hear our voices, fulfil the thoughts of men.
Hear the prayer we bring,
and deign to grant what we ask:
on earth a godly life,
after life a dwelling in paradise. Lord, have mercy.*

DIPLOMATIC TEXT

The diplomatic text is that of (K); ǫ is a nasal vowel.

- 1 Bogy rodzicza dziewicza bogem sławiena maria
Vtwego syna gospodzina matko swolena maria
Sziszczi nam spwczǫ nam kyrieleyson
- 2 Twego dzela krzcziczela boszicze
Vslisz głosi naplen misli człowiecze
Slisz modlitwǫ yǫsz nosimi
A dacz raczi gegosz prosimi
a naswecze zbożni pobith
posziwocze raski pzbith ky'eleyson

Bogurodzica

ANONYMOUS

Bar lines are editorial. Neume groups follow (K).

Cant.
I
B o-gu-rodzi- ca dzie-wi- ca, Bogiem sławie- na Ma- ry- ja, U twe-go sy- na, Gospo-
dzi- na, Matko zwo- le-na, Ma- ry- ja! Zyszczy nam, spuści nam. Ky-ri- e e- le- i-son.

2. Twe-go dzie- la Krzci-cie- la, bo- ży- ce, u-słysz gło- sy, na-pełń myśl- li człowiecze. Słysz mo-
dlitwę, jaż no-simy, a dać ra- czy, je-goż pro-simy: a na świe-cie zbożny po- byt, po żywocie
rajski prze- byt. Ky-ri- e e- le- i-son.



CRITICAL NOTES

MUSICAL VARIANTS

Pitches C D E F G a b c' d'; hyphens join notes on one syllable. (?!) marks readings Chybiński thought corrupt.

LOC.	LEMMA	READINGS
1.1	<i>Bogurodzica</i>	(K) D C F E-D-C D (K70) D D-C F E-C-E D (W) D C F E D
1.2	<i>dziewica</i>	(K) F G-F-G a (K70) F G bb a (W) F G a
1.3	<i>Bogiem sławiena</i>	(K) c' d' c' a-G-F F (K70) b d' c' a-G F (?!) (W) c' d' c' a F
1.4	<i>Maryja</i>	(K) F-G-a-G-E-C D (K70) F-a-G-E C E D (?!) (W) F a G E D D (?!)
1.5	<i>U twego syna</i>	(K) d' c' a-G-F G-F-G a (K70) a G F G bb a a (W) short form beginning on a; (K70) and (W) both lack d' c'
1.6	<i>Gospodzina</i>	(K) c' d' c' a G F (K70) c' d' c' a-G F (W) c' d' c' a F
1.7	<i>Matko</i>	(K) c' a-G-F (K70) c' a-G (?!) (W) c' a
1.8	<i>zwolena, Maryja</i>	as 1.4 in all witnesses
1.9	<i>Zyszczy nam</i>	(K) F G-F-G a (K70) F G bb a (W) F G a
1.10	<i>spuści nam</i>	(K) (W) c' b d' (K70) c' b d' d' (?!)
1.11	<i>Kyrie</i>	(K) c' a G-F (K70) (W) c' a F
2.1	<i>Twego dzieła Krzyciela</i>	(K) D-E D-C F G E C D (K70) D D-C F F G G E E C D D (?!) (W) D D-C F G E C-E D
2.2	<i>Bożyce</i>	as 1.4 in all witnesses
2.3	<i>uśysz głosy</i>	(K) a G-F G-F-G a (K70) a G-F G bb a (W) a G-F G a a
2.4	<i>napętni myśli człowiecze</i>	(K) D C F G E C D (K70) (W) <i>napętnij</i> , with an extra note
2.5	<i>Słysz modlitwę, jaż nosimy</i>	(K) C F G E-D-E C D E D (K70) C G a bb a a D D C C F F E D (W) C F G a D D C F G a a
2.6	<i>a dać raczy</i>	(K) a G-F G-F-G a (K70) a G F G bb a a (?!)
2.7	<i>jegoż prosimy</i>	(K) D-E D-C F G a (K70) D D-C F G bb a
2.8	<i>a na świecie zbożny pobyt</i>	(K) c' a c' G c' a-G-F G-F-G a (K70) c' b c' d' G G c' a G G bb a (W) a c' d' G G c' a F G a a
2.9	<i>po żywocie rajski przebył</i>	(K) a c' d' G c' a-G-F G-F-G a (K70) a bb c' d' G c' a F F bb a (W) a c' d' G c' a F G a a
2.10	<i>Kyrieieison</i>	(K) a G F F-G-a-G E D D

TEXTUAL VARIANTS

Variants are normalised; spelling differences are ignored.

LOC.	LEMMA	READINGS
1.1	<i>Bogu rodzica</i>	(K) (K408) <i>Boga rodzica</i> (WA) (CZ) (K3) (Ł) (M) (H) (S)
1.1	<i>sławiena</i>	(K) (K408) <i>sławiona</i> (WA) (CZ) (K3) (Ł) (M) (H) (S)

LOC.	LEMMA	READINGS
1.2	<i>U twego</i>	(K) (WA) (CZ) (K3) (Ł) (H) (S) <i>W twego</i> (K408) (M)
1.2	<i>Gospodzina</i>	(K) (K408) (WA) (CZ) (Ł) (M) <i>gospodina</i> (K3) <i>Gospodynia</i> (H) <i>hospodyna</i> (S)
1.2	<i>zwolena</i>	(K) (K408) <i>zwolona</i> (WA) (Ł) (M) (H) (S) <i>zbozenia</i> (CZ) <i>zwolienia</i> (K3)
1.3	<i>Zyszczy ... spuści nam</i>	(K) (K408) (WA) (Ł) <i>zyszczysz ... spuszcysz</i> (CZ) <i>zyszczy ... spust winam</i> (K3) (M) <i>ziścisz ... spuścisz</i> (H) <i>ziści ... spuści</i> (S)
2.1	<i>Twego dzieła</i>	(K) (K408) (WA) (CZ) <i>Twego syna</i> (K3) (Ł) (M) (H) (S)
2.1	<i>Krzyciela</i>	<i>zbawiciela</i> (M) [Kr]zyciela <i>zbawiciela</i> (K3)
2.1	<i>Bożyce</i>	(K) (K408) <i>zbożnica</i> (WA) (CZ) <i>zbożny czas</i> (Ł) (H) (S) <i>zbożnika</i> (M)
2.2	<i>napetń</i>	(K) <i>napetni</i> (K408) (WA) (CZ) (K3) (Ł) (M) (H) (S)
2.3	<i>jąż nosimy</i>	(K) (K408) (WA) <i>jenżeć nosimy</i> (CZ) <i>jenże (cię) prosimy</i> (Ł) (M) (H) (S)
2.4	<i>A dać raczy</i>	(K) (WA) <i>Oddać raczy</i> (K408) (M) <i>O dać</i> (CZ) <i>O o dać</i> (Ł) <i>O o daci</i> (H) <i>To dać</i> (S)
2.5	<i>a na świecie</i>	(K) (K408) <i>daj na świecie</i> (WA) (CZ) (Ł) (H) (S) <i>daj nam na świecie</i> (M) <i>dai na świecie</i> (K3)
2.5–6	<i>pobyt ... przebyt</i>	<i>pobyt ... przybytk</i> (WA)
2.6	<i>rajski</i>	<i>raski</i> (K)
refr.	<i>Kirielejson</i>	<i>kyrieleyson</i> (K) (st. 2 ky'eleyson) <i>kyon</i> (CZ) <i>kyeon</i> (WA) <i>Kyrie eleison</i> (M) (H) (S)

NOTES

Staves and clefs. System 1 has four lines, the rest five; the lowest line also serves as the text baseline. In system 2 the clefs move for *Matko* and return before *zwolena*. Read with these clefs, *Matko* is c' a-G-F.

1.1. *Bogv rodzicza* is two words, with the dative *Bogu* in a genitive sense (Łoś). All other copies have *Boga rodzica*, the name used in the 1410 *Chronica conflictus* ('Chronicle of the battle') and by Długosz. *Stawiena* and *zwolena* are Old Polish forms, not Czechisms. The C on -gu- is faint but legible.

1.2. *U*: two separate puncta, d' c', carry the syllable. The later musical witnesses drop both notes and so lose the octave leap from *Maryja*. Over -dzi-na of *Gospodzina* the a and G stand close and the F apart, which gives c' a-G | F.

2.1. *dzieła* means 'for the sake of' (later *dla*). Łoś knew it in no other Old Polish text and used it to date the song to the 13th century. The printed tradition replaced it with *syna*; modern popular texts misread it as *dzieła*. *Bożyce* is the vocative of *bożyc*, 'son of God'.

2.2. The C on -petń is not visible in the facsimile; only the D over *naplen* can be read. It is supplied from the parallel 2.1 and from every other transcription.

2.4. The initial of *A dać* has the same design as the *U* of *Uśysz*. This likely explains Pilat's reading *O dacz*; Łoś, Kalina and Woronczak read *A*.

2.4–10. From *A dać raczy* the neumes are larger and more widely spaced, possibly in another hand (Chybiński). The forms and pitches are the same as before.

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